

English IPA Guide

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The International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA) is a convention for writing the sounds of languages. For Project 3, you will need to transcribe English words (specifically, unique names) using IPA.

There are different ways of transcribing the phonemes (more on this later) of Mainstream American English using IPA. The following guide shows you the version you should use for Project 3.

Many of the IPA symbols represent the same sound as in MAE (black) but some represent different sounds (purple)

Consonants

/p/	pick	/b/	bit
/t/	tick	/d/	dip
/k/	kick	/g/	get
		/r/	water
/tʃ/	cheer	/dʒ/	jeer
/m/	mit	/m/	sim
/n/	nit	/n/	sin
/ŋ/	—	/ŋ/	sing
/l/	lip		
/w/	wack	/j/	yack
/ɹ/	rack		
/f/	fan	/v/	van
/θ/	thigh	/ð/	thy
/s/	sink	/z/	zinc
/ʃ/	assure	/ʒ/	azure
/h/	hat		

Vowels

For historical reasons, the IPA symbols for vowels are, for the most part, different than the corresponding English vowels (but consider cases like *dune* /dun/ and many words borrowed from other languages).

[i]	beet			[u]	boot
[ɪ]	bit			[ʊ]	book
[eɪ]	bait	[ə]	but	[oʊ]	boat
[ɛ]	bet	[ʌ]	butt	[ɔ]	bought
		[ə]			
		&			
		about			
[æ]	bat			[ɑ]	bot
[oɪ]	oink	[aɪ]	I	[aʊ]	out

Note that the vowel sequence at the end of *idea* and *Sophia* is transcribed as [iə].

Examples

Here are some transcribed examples to get you started.

Traditional Mainstream American English Names

David	/deɪvəd/
Mary	/mɛɪi/, /mæɪi/
Matthew	/mæθju/
Anne	/æn/
Liam	/liəm/
Olivia	/əlɪviə/, /owlɪviə/
Charlotte	/ʃɑɪlət/
Sophia	/sowfiə/
Theodore	/θiədɔɪ/
James	/dʒejmz/
Patricia	/pətɪfə/

Tragedeighs

Xylyx	/zajləks/
Axxtyn	/ækstən/
Fructosa	/fruktowsə/
Hallzee	/halzi/
Ptobias	/towbajəs/, /towbiəs/
Rielee	/ɹajli/
Dareaux	/dɛɹɔw/
Machaela	/məkejlə/
Mekayla	/məkejlə/
Micaela	/məkejlə/
McKaylah	/məkejlə/